

THEATRE

REBEL WITH A CAUSE

***Matilda: The Musical*,** on at NMACC, Mumbai and based on the Roald Dahl bestseller, is about a feisty girl who takes on the vicious headmistress

Flying paper planes. Kids on swings. An eight-member band performing 16 songs. And what Natalie Gilhome, resident director of the Royal Shakespeare Company (RSC), calls "theatrical magic". These are just some of the things that audiences will get to see in *Matilda: The Musical*, which began its two-week run at the Grand Theatre at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai on May 16. And because this is a production that replicates the visual vocabulary and technical flair of London's West End show, Gilhome and her team are travelling with 12 containers worth of sets, props and costumes.

Adapted from what's perhaps Roald Dahl's second most famous children's work—after *Charlie and the Chocolate Factory*—*Matilda*, published in 1988, has acquired new resonance with each passing decade. There was the beloved 1996 film that still draws repeat viewings and, more recently, a musical (2022), adapted from the play itself, on Netflix. That's part of its appeal, says Gilhome, in addition to its wee protagonist who is a rebel with a cause: in this case to bring down the vicious head-

FILM

Dial M for Magical Effects

When it comes to visual effects, **Namit Malhotra** is at the top of the game globally

Namit Malhotra loves spectacle. CEO of DNEG, the visual effects company that has won seven Oscars so far for films like *Dune*, Malhotra is in the midst of an action-packed month. May 17 marks the release of the animated film *The Garfield Movie*, of which he is also a producer, followed by *Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga* (May 24), on which DNEG has worked extensively. They're also putting the finishing touches on *Kalki 2898 AD*, the multilingual sci-fi action drama starring Prabhas, Deepika Padukone and Amitabh Bachchan, which releases in June, and are in the midst of shooting what Malhotra describes a "childhood dream", the epic *Ramayana*, starring Ranbir Kapoor, Sai Pallavi and Yash. It's all

